



AFP

WHEN TOP GUNS VISIT
Far left, Indian army chief Gen. Upendra Dwivedi visits a forward location of the Chinar Corps in Kashmir, May 15; Pakistan army chief Gen. Asim Munir at a Rawalpindi hospital, May 12

and in another, talked of working with leaders of both countries to see "if after a 'thousand years', a solution can be arrived at concerning Kashmir". Equally mortifying was Trump wanting these two countries to increase trade, saying, "Let's not trade nuclear missiles, let's trade the things that you make so beautifully." Not only did the re-hyphenation of India with Pakistan sting, adding insult to the injury was Trump equating India, the victim of a terror attack, with its perpetrator Pakistan.

Ashley Tellis, Senior Fellow at the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, is dismissive of Trump and Rubio's claims of mediation, saying, "It's a promise that simply could not be implemented. I think Trump has a billion things on his hand—we are still waiting for the Gaza ceasefire and the end of the Ukraine war which was supposed to happen 24 hours after he came to power." He believes that contrary to popular notions, both India and Pakistan went into the war reluctantly and, for them, the hostilities were an unwelcome surprise. "The turning point," says Tellis, "came when both sides believed that from their vantage point they had done enough damage to each other and to signal that the provocations will not go unanswered. At some points, your objectives for war shape your choices. And, in that context, the US intervention made a difference by persuading both they had done enough and may regret any further steps they may take. For that, you should give Rubio credit."

However, the American leadership's loose statements made it look as though India had yielded to US pressure rather than supporting the narrative that it was Pakistan that had pleaded with India for ceasefire because of its mounting military losses. "The lesson for Mr Modi," says Haqqani, "is to be careful of drawing too close to Trump as he remains unpredictable." As blasphemous for India was Rubio's statement about talks at a neutral place, disregarding New Delhi's steadfast policy of not entering into a dialogue with Islamabad till it stopped sponsoring terror. Worse, Trump wanted to insinuate himself into the Kashmir space when India had made it clear that there would be no more discussion with Pakistan on the status of the Valley after the abrogation of Article 370. Modi indirectly dismissed Trump's assertions in his speech when he said, "India's stand is very clear: terror and talks, terror and trade cannot go together." He also indicated that India would lift the suspension of the IWT only after Pakistan turned off the tap on terror, since, as he put it eloquently, "Water and blood cannot flow together." As for Trump's offer of mediating the Kashmir issue, Modi disregarded it, saying, "I would like to tell the global community that our stated policy is: if there are talks with Pakistan, it will only be on terrorism, it will only be on Pakistan-occupied Kashmir."

TO THE USA, MODI HAS MADE IT SUFFICIENTLY CLEAR THAT KASHMIR IS OFF THE TABLE; ANY TALK THAT WILL TAKE PLACE WILL ONLY BE ON TERRORISM AND PoK

What the American leadership's assertions did do, though, was to embolden Pakistan, as Shehbaz declared that they had not only withstood India's assault successfully but also repaid in kind. Pakistan claimed it had downed six Indian aircraft, five of them on the first night of the strike. India has not denied that charge so far, though Air Marshal A.K. Bharti, India's director general of air operations, did say that while all Indian fighter pilots were safe, "losses are part of combat". Ajay Bisaria, a former Indian high commissioner to Pakistan, says, "Let's be clear that India has achieved its objectives of both accountability of terror perpetrators and the setting up of a credible deterrence against their sponsors, the Pakistan state.